

cutting down unnecessary features and keeping the browser simple. Consequently, as compared to the Mozilla browser, Firefox is leaner, cleaner and faster. The user interface is simple and doesn't overwhelm the user in any way. The main interface consists of menus and toolbars—no Opera-style Panels here.

Though tabbed browsing was introduced by Opera, the Mozilla foundation used it as a pivotal feature in Firefox. One small niggling issue with the tabs is the exclusion of a close button on each tab—instead, you have a single close button on the extreme right, which is used to close any tab. The tabs can be rearranged by simply dragging and dropping them in the required order.

We hope to see thumbnails for tabs in version 2 of Firefox.

Customisation

Being open source has its own advantages, and this is evident with Firefox's customisation options. The real meat of this browser lies in the degree of customisation it offers. Unlike Opera, which offers limitless customisation, Firefox is a little restrictive in terms of customisation of critical parameters. Being skinnable, Firefox not only supports third-party skins, but is also relatively easy to skin yourself.

What sets Firefox apart from all other browsers is "Extensions." These are small plug-ins that add additional features to an otherwise bland browser. The Mozilla community is highly active, and you have over a thousand extensions to

choose from—not all are useful, though. (Refer to this month's *30 Minutes Expert* for more on this.) With Firefox 1.5.0.1, Mozilla has included an Extension Manager, which checks for upgrades of all installed extensions simultaneously, thus automating the process.

With Firefox, you also get an integrated search bar for various search engines such as Google and Yahoo!, and you can add your own engines. RSS support is not as good as in Opera, but it's good enough to get your work done.

Security

Firefox includes a pop-up blocker. Its lack of support for ActiveX and VBScript gives it an additional layer of security.

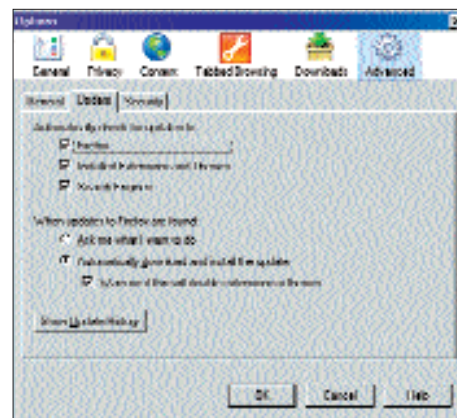
Speed

Speed is something Firefox is known for, and it pretty much deserves the accolades. The best part about Firefox is that it first renders the text and then gets all the required images, which essentially cuts down the waiting time. This is a boon in the Indian context, since the majority of people across the country are still on dial-up connections.

We would have loved to test version 2 of Firefox, but unfortunately, there are no details available about when it will release.

Summing It Up

In this head-to-head comparison of the three best browsers today, the most probable contender for the crown is Opera 9. There is still some time before it releases, but much is promised—and we don't think we'll be let down. Try the preview for yourself—you can find it on the Digit CD with this issue.

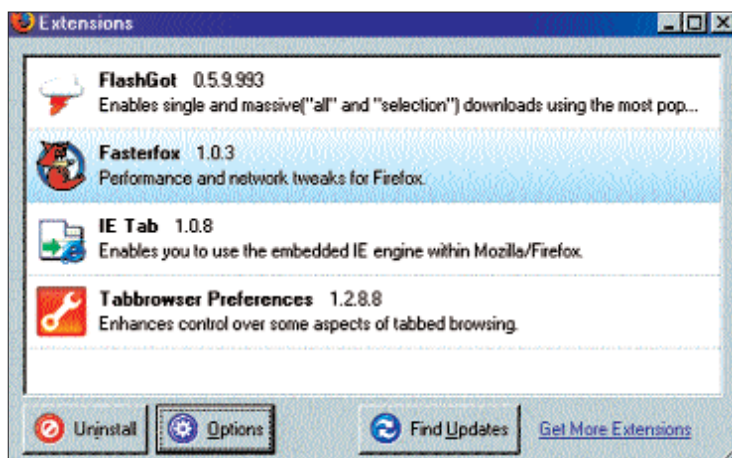


The Firefox browser and extensions can be automatically updated all at once

As for IE7, it's still too early to pass judgement, but looking at the improvements Microsoft has already implemented, we expect the most-used browser to scale up to new heights. The fact that it comes bundled with Windows doesn't hurt it at all.

Firefox has the advantage of a huge supporting community. However, with nothing but a crude roadmap for the future, we really cannot judge how successful version 2.0 of Firefox will be. ☐

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Extensions—the meat of the Firefox browser!

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